

A Coupled Radiative–Microphysical Model of Titan’s Organic Haze: Energy Balance, a Fractal-Aggregate Scaling Law, and Their Feedback

The Titan Haze Feedback Project

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Abstract

Titan’s organic haze is radiatively and microphysically active: it absorbs sunlight and warms the stratosphere, emits in the thermal infrared, and its vertical and size structure is set by coagulation and sedimentation of fractal aggregates whose rates depend on the local temperature. This makes the haze a genuine feedback element rather than a passive tracer. We outline a four-stage program to isolate this feedback in a one-dimensional column: (i) a multi-stream discrete-ordinates (DISORT/pydisort) radiative energy balance for the temperature profile; (ii) an analytic *scaling law* for the aerosol microphysics that maps temperature, monomer radius, and fractal dimension onto the haze number- and size-profile; (iii) iteration of (i) and (ii) to a self-consistent fixed point to diagnose the feedback; and (iv) coupling of photochemical haze production into the loop. Our central methodological result is the scaling law. Adopting a monodisperse, self-similar closure $C(z, N) = n(z) \delta(N - \bar{N}(z))$ for the concentration of aggregates of N monomers at altitude z , the population balance reduces from an integro-differential equation in (z, N) to a compact boundary-value problem in z for the number density $n(z)$ and mean size $\bar{N}(z)$. In the sedimentation-dominated limit it collapses further to a single first-order ordinary differential equation, $d\bar{N}/dz = -\beta(\bar{N}, z) P/[2\omega(\bar{N}, z)^2]$, whose asymptotic solutions grow as $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^2$ in the free-molecular upper haze and $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^{1/2}$ in the continuum lower atmosphere. This law is inexpensive enough to embed inside the radiative iteration, closing the feedback loop.

1 Introduction

On Titan the photochemical haze is not a passive optical load. It absorbs solar radiation—heating the stratosphere—and emits in the thermal infrared, where it contributes a non-negligible fraction of the planetary emission and warms the troposphere (Tomasko et al., 2008). At the same time its vertical extent and particle sizes are governed by aerosol microphysics: monomers produced high in the atmosphere coagulate into fractal aggregates that sediment downward (Cabane et al., 1993; Rannou et al., 2004; Burgalat and Rannou, 2017). Crucially, the microphysical rates are temperature dependent—the Brownian coagulation kernel scales as T/η , the gas viscosity $\eta(T)$ and mean free path $\lambda(T, P)$ enter the settling velocity, and the free-molecular kernel carries a $T^{1/2}$ factor. Temperature sets the microphysics, the microphysics sets the opacity, and the opacity sets the temperature: a closed feedback loop.

Most existing models break this loop in one direction. Radiative studies prescribe the haze from observations (Tomasko et al., 2008; Lombardo and Lora, 2023), while fully coupled treatments embed microphysics in a three-dimensional general circulation model (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025), which is faithful but expensive and difficult to interrogate. Our aim

is intermediate: to isolate the one-dimensional radiative $\leftrightarrow$ microphysical feedback with a fast, analytic microphysics so the coupled system can be iterated cheaply to a self-consistent state and the feedback gain measured directly.

2 Model overview

The program proceeds in four stages.

Step 1 — Radiative energy balance. A 1-D plane-parallel Titan column solved with a multi-stream discrete-ordinates method (pydisort/DISORT; Stamnes et al., 1988). Short-wave absorption by CH₄ and haze; longwave cooling by gas lines, collision-induced absorption, and haze emission. Iterated to radiative(–convective) equilibrium for $T(z)$ (Sec. 3).

Step 2 — Microphysical scaling law. A closed relation for the steady aggregate population, coagulation + sedimentation $\rightarrow$ density/size profile, in the form $C(z, N) dz dN = f(z, N, T, d, D)$ (Sec. 4). This is the methodological core of the present note.

Step 3 — Coupled iteration. Map the microphysical moments to layer optical properties, feed DISORT, update $T(z)$, and iterate to a fixed point; diagnose the feedback (Sec. 5).

Step 4 — Photochemistry. Promote the imposed haze production rate to an output of a photochemical module, closing the radiation $\leftrightarrow$ chemistry $\leftrightarrow$ microphysics loop (Sec. 6).

We note that none of the reference studies (Tomasko et al., 2008; Lombardo and Lora, 2023; de Batz de Trenquell  on et al., 2025) use DISORT—they employ doubling–adding, line-by-line, or two-stream solvers—so the multi-stream solver here is an upgrade, validated against the net-flux and heating/cooling tables of Tomasko et al. (2008).

3 Radiative energy balance (Step 1)

The column spans the surface to ~ 540 km. Following the spectral split of Lombardo and Lora (2023), shortwave (2000–40000 cm^{−1}, $< 5 \mu\text{m}$) radiative transfer treats solar absorption and multiple scattering by haze (single-scattering albedo ω_0 , asymmetry g), while the longwave band (1–2000 cm^{−1}) handles thermal cooling with gas line opacity, N₂–N₂, N₂–CH₄, CH₄–CH₄, and N₂–H₂ collision-induced absorption, and a (near-)purely-absorbing haze. Gas opacities use the correlated- k method with HITRAN line data; methane shortwave coefficients follow the Huygens/DISR measurements supplemented above 1600 nm by laboratory data. The temperature profile is relaxed until shortwave heating balances longwave cooling.

The validation target is the energy budget of Tomasko et al. (2008): a surface net solar flux of 0.574 W m^{−2} (about 11% of the incident flux) rising to ~ 4.1 W m^{−2} near 400 km; a net heating that exceeds cooling by at most ~ 0.5 K per Titan day near 120 km; and a thermal cooling rate peaking near 21 K per Titan day around 340 km. Roughly 80% of the top-of-atmosphere sunlight is absorbed in the column, $\sim 40\%$ below 80 km, the haze raising the planetary thermal emission by $\sim 15\%$ and reducing the tropospheric cooling rate by $\sim 30\%$ below 50 km. Baseline atmospheric and compositional inputs are collected in Table 2.

4 Microphysical scaling law (Step 2)

We seek the steady population $C(z, N)$ of aggregates containing N monomers at altitude z (positive upward), built from production, Brownian coagulation, and gravitational sedimentation, with T the temperature, d the monomer radius, and D the fractal dimension. The physical ingredients—kernels, settling velocity, and fractal radius laws—follow Burgalat and Rannou (2017), with parameters from de Batz de Trenquell  on et al. (2025).

4.1 Monodisperse, self-similar closure

We adopt a monodisperse closure: at each altitude the aggregates share a single characteristic monomer count $\bar{N}(z)$,

$$C(z, N) = n(z) \delta(N - \bar{N}(z)), \quad (1)$$

so the unknown fields are the number density $n(z)$ [m^{-3}] and the mean size $\bar{N}(z)$. The count $\bar{N}$ is treated as a *continuous monomer-volume count*: it measures particle volume in units of one monomer's volume, so $\bar{N} < 1$ denotes a sub-monomer sphere of radius $r = d \bar{N}^{1/3} < d$. This keeps mass bookkeeping exact through both coalescence (merging spheres, $\bar{N} < 1$) and aggregation (sticking, $\bar{N} \geq 1$). The closure is exact for the moments $M_0 = n$ and $M_1 = n\bar{N}$; it approximates the kernel by evaluating it at the mean size.

4.2 Fractal geometry and transport coefficients

An aggregate of N monomers of radius d and fractal dimension D has a mass (volume-equivalent) radius and a mobility (drag) radius

$$r(N) = d N^{1/3}, \quad r_a(N) = d N^{1/D}, \quad V(N) = \frac{4}{3} \pi d^3 N, \quad (2)$$

with the apparent-bulk conversion $r_a = E^{-1} r^{3/D}$, $E = d^{(D-3)/D}$ (Burgalat and Rannou, 2017). We carry two growth phases explicitly,

$$D(\bar{N}) = \begin{cases} 3 & \bar{N} < 1 \quad (\text{compact coalesced spheres, } E = 1, r_a = r), \\ D & \bar{N} \geq 1 \quad (\text{fractal aggregates, e.g. } D = 2), \end{cases} \quad (3)$$

the switch at $\bar{N} = 1$ being continuous in r_a (both give $r_a = d$).

The Stokes settling velocity with first-order Cunningham slip, generalized to fractal D (Burgalat and Rannou, 2017, Eq. 29), is

$$\omega(N, z) = \frac{2\rho_p g(z) d^2}{9\eta(z)} \left[N^{(D-1)/D} + \frac{A\lambda(z)}{d} N^{(D-2)/D} \right], \quad (4)$$

with $A = 1.591$, gas viscosity $\eta(z) = \eta(T)$, mean free path $\lambda(z) = \lambda(T, P)$, gravity $g(z)$, and $D = D(\bar{N})$. The equal-size Brownian coagulation kernel is bridged across the Knudsen regimes by the Fuchs harmonic mean of its continuum and free-molecular forms,

$$\beta_{\text{CO}}(N, N) = \frac{2k_B T}{3\eta} (r_{ai} + r_{aj}) \left(\frac{1}{r_{ai}} + \frac{1}{r_{aj}} \right) \cdot [\text{slip}], \quad (5)$$

$$\beta_{\text{FM}}(N, N) = \left(\frac{6k_B T}{\rho_p} \right)^{1/2} (r_{ai} + r_{aj})^2 \left(r_i^{-3} + r_j^{-3} \right)^{1/2}, \quad (6)$$

$$\beta(N, N; z) = \frac{\beta_{\text{CO}} \beta_{\text{FM}}}{\beta_{\text{CO}} + \beta_{\text{FM}}}. \quad (7)$$

Both ω and β are thus explicit functions of $(\bar{N}, z, T, d, D)$; the temperature enters through $k_B T / \eta$, $(k_B T / \rho_p)^{1/2}$, $\eta(T)$, and $\lambda(T, P)$.

4.3 Governing boundary-value problem

Working with the aggregate number density n and the monomer-volume density $M \equiv n\bar{N}$ (mass $= m_1 M$, $m_1 = \rho_p \frac{4}{3} \pi d^3$), the steady 1-D balance for any density q with downward settling speed

ω and eddy diffusivity $K(z)$ reads $d_z[\omega q + K d_z q] = L_q - S_q$, where $\omega q + K d_z q$ is the downward flux, S_q the production, and L_q the loss. Applied to the two densities,

$$\frac{d}{dz} \left[\omega(\bar{N}, z) M + K \frac{dM}{dz} \right] = -S_M(z), \quad (8)$$

$$\frac{d}{dz} \left[\omega(\bar{N}, z) n + K \frac{dn}{dz} \right] = \frac{1}{2} \beta(\bar{N}, z) n^2 - S_n(z). \quad (9)$$

Equation (8) expresses monomer conservation: coagulation merges particles but preserves total monomer volume, so the only monomer source is production. Equation (9) expresses Smoluchowski number loss—each collision removes one aggregate at rate $\frac{1}{2}\beta n^2$ —plus seeding. With $\bar{N} = M/n$ and $D = D(\bar{N})$, this is a coupled two-point boundary-value problem for $M(z), n(z)$. The production source is a Gaussian (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025, Eq. 5),

$$S_M(z) = \frac{Q_p}{m_1} G(z), \quad G(z) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi} \Delta z} \exp \left[-\frac{(z - z_0)^2}{2 \Delta z^2} \right], \quad S_n = \frac{S_M}{N_{\text{seed}}}, \quad (10)$$

with $N_{\text{seed}} = (r_p/d)^3$. Boundary conditions are vanishing densities at the model top and settling-only deposition ($d_z M = d_z n = 0$) at the surface. A first integral of (8) well below the source recovers the constant downward monomer flux $\omega M + K d_z M = P$, with $P = Q_p/m_1$.

4.4 Sedimentation-dominated limit: the master scaling ODE

Setting $K \rightarrow 0$ yields a closed-form law—both a physical limit and the initial guess for the BVP solver. Monomer-flux constancy gives the classical result that the haze mass density equals the mass flux divided by the fall speed,

$$\omega n \bar{N} = P \implies n(z) = \frac{P}{\omega \bar{N}}, \quad \rho_h(z) = \frac{Q_p}{\omega(\bar{N}, z)}. \quad (11)$$

Substituting $\omega n = P/\bar{N}$ into (9) (below the source) collapses the system to a single first-order ODE for the mean size,

$$\boxed{\frac{d\bar{N}}{dz} = -\frac{\beta(\bar{N}, z) P}{2\omega(\bar{N}, z)^2}}, \quad \bar{N}(z_0) = N_{\text{seed}}, \quad (12)$$

integrated downward and switching $D(\bar{N})$ from 3 to D at $\bar{N} = 1$. Because the right-hand side is negative, $\bar{N}$ grows as the particle falls; the number density and sizes then follow from (11) and (2).

4.5 Asymptotic scalings

Holding the background quantities $(T, \eta, \lambda, g, \rho_p, P)$ roughly constant over a scale height, β and ω become pure powers of $\bar{N}$ and (12) integrates to power laws (Table 1). Just below the production region the haze is free-molecular and the mean size grows as $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^2$; deep in the dense lower atmosphere the continuum kernel is size-independent and growth slows to $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^{1/2}$. The full Fuchs kernel (7) interpolates smoothly between these limits, which is why (12)/(8)–(9) are integrated numerically rather than reduced to a single exponent.

5 Coupled iteration (Step 3)

Per layer the microphysics supplies the number density $n(z)$ and the characteristic radius $r_a(z) = d \bar{N}^{1/D}$. These map to layer optical properties via a precomputed aggregate-optics

Table 1: Asymptotic scaling exponents for equal-size aggregates, with depth $\equiv z_0 - z$. The spherical phase ($\bar{N} < 1$) uses $D = 3$.

Regime	$\beta(\bar{N}) \propto$	$\omega(\bar{N}) \propto$	$d\bar{N}/dz \propto -\bar{N}^s, s =$	$\bar{N}(\text{depth}), D = 2$
Continuum ($\text{Kn} \ll 1$, low alt.)	$\bar{N}^0$	$\bar{N}^{(D-1)/D}$	$-2(D-1)/D$	$\bar{N} \propto \text{depth}^{1/2}$
Free-molecular ($\text{Kn} \gg 1$, high alt.)	$\bar{N}^{2/D-1/2}$	$\bar{N}^{(D-2)/D}$	$(6-2D)/D - 1/2$	$\bar{N} \propto \text{depth}^2$

Table 2: Baseline microphysical and atmospheric parameters adopted for Titan. Sources: T08 (Tomasko et al., 2008), L23 (Lombardo and Lora, 2023), BR17 (Burgalat and Rannou, 2017), dT25 (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025).

Quantity	Symbol	Value	Source
Fractal dimension	D	2.0 (free, 2–3; 3 $\Rightarrow$ spheres)	dT25
Monomer radius	d	50 nm	dT25 (T08)
Production seed radius	r_p	10 nm	dT25
Aerosol density	ρ_p	800 kg m ^{−3}	dT25
Mass production rate	$\mathcal{Q}_p$	2.1×10^{-13} kg m ^{−2} s ^{−1}	dT25 (T08)
Production altitude	z_0	415 km $\approx$ 1 Pa	dT25
Production width	Δz	20 km	dT25
Charge density	n_e	15 e [−] μm^{-1}	dT25
Slip-flow constant	A	1.591	BR17
Surface temperature	T_s	93.5 K	T08
Surface pressure	P_s	~ 1.47 bar	L23
Stratospheric CH ₄	–	1.4%	T08
Haze opacity scale height	H	65 km (above 80 km)	T08
RT grid	–	0–540 km, ~ 50 layers	T08, L23
Shortwave / longwave split	–	5 μm	L23

table (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025, Eqs. 16–18): the optical thickness is $\Delta\tau(\lambda, z) = n(z) C_{\text{ext}}(r_a, \lambda) \Delta z$, with mean single-scattering albedo and asymmetry parameter obtained by opacity weighting. The aggregate projected area scales as $\bar{N}^{2/D} d^2$. The feedback loop is then

$$T(z) \xrightarrow{\text{DISORT}} \eta(T), \lambda(T, P) \xrightarrow{(12)/\S 4} n(z), \bar{N}(z) \xrightarrow{\text{optics}} \Delta\tau, \omega_0, g \xrightarrow{\text{DISORT}} T(z),$$

iterated to a fixed point. The sign and magnitude of the feedback gain (e.g. $dT/d\tau$ at convergence) are read off directly from the converged sequence.

6 Photochemistry in the loop (Step 4)

In Steps 1–3 the production rate $\mathcal{Q}_p$ and seed properties are imposed ($\mathcal{Q}_p = 2.1 \times 10^{-13}$ kg m^{−2} s^{−1} at $z_0 \approx 415$ km; de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025). Step 4 promotes $\mathcal{Q}_p$ to an output of a photochemical module driven by CH₄/N₂ photolysis, so the haze mass flux responds to the radiation field and composition, completing the radiation $\leftrightarrow$ chemistry $\leftrightarrow$ microphysics feedback.

7 Baseline parameters

Status and approximations. The monodisperse closure replaces the true size spread by $\bar{N}$ and evaluates the kernel at the mean size; real distributions coagulate somewhat faster, an $O(1)$ correction absorbable into a prefactor on β and calibratable against a full population-balance

run. The spherical→fractal switch at $\bar{N} = 1$ is treated as instantaneous. Background profiles $\eta(T)$, $\lambda(T, P)$ are taken from N_2 kinetic theory, $g(z)$ from Titan gravity, and the eddy diffusivity $K(z)$ from a standard Titan profile (Vuitton et al., 2019). Charge inhibition (a multiplicative factor on β) is deferred until the base loop closes. Tables 1 and 2 and Eqs. (8)–(12) define the model to be implemented next.

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